DRAWING 1 / CHATHAM 2025 / STILL LIFE PROJECT REVIEW

ANNOUNCEMENTS

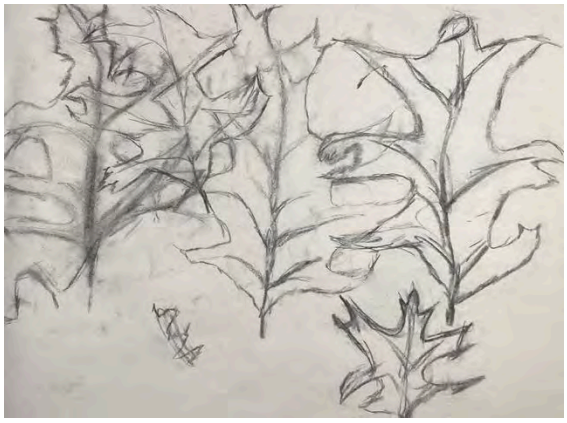
My name is Peter Mandradjieff and I am an artist and teacher living in Pittsburgh. I enjoy sharing my knowledge about art and inspiring others to be creative. Drawing is an exciting and rigorous activity, both conceptually and physically challenging. I see drawing as a fundamental skill, not only necessary to develop a unique artistic voice, but also to unlock different ways of thinking and understanding the world. In this class we will move in stages through the skills of observational drawing, employing contour line, negative space, tonal value, and perspective to create expressive charcoal drawings. Observation also requires interpretation, and so we will analyze historic and contemporary drawing to guide our contextual thinking and ability to articulate our experiences.

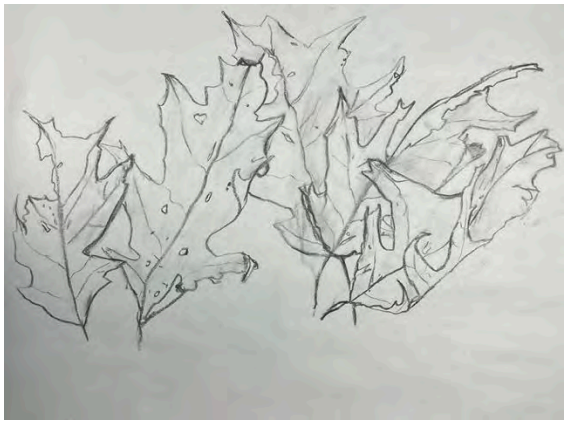
Drawing from Observation / Chapter 4 / PDF

Please review all of Chapter 4 (p. 29-44) Intuitive Gesture from Drawing from Observation: an Introduction to Perceptual Drawing by Brian Curtis. PDF attached below. During the third class we will practice and discuss intuitive gesture drawing. This is one of the only readings you will be asked to complete for the course.

Henri Matisse / Drawing Form

Great short video of Matisse in action drawing. Observe how his eyes dart from the figure to the drawing, back and forth. This will be how we will draw in class. During the video Matisse says "I don't paint things. I only paint the difference between things. " What do you think he is aiming at with this comment? What could this possibly mean? Matisse lead revolutionary developments in the visual arts during the opening decades of the twentieth century with his original and expressive drawings and paintings.





DAY 1 & 2: Upside Down / Contour Drawing

We covered an essential drawing idea during the first class. The “upside-down” drawing is designed to help you experience "observation without judgement." To see forms without preconceived ideas interfering with your observations. This will be the approach we use throughout the class. This approach takes mental toughness and is not the default way we experience the world.

We also practiced the technique of “contour line“ that describes volume through careful observation of detail, foreshortening, and overlapping elements. We practiced creating a lost and found line with the use of a kneaded erasure. We also employed time restraints to quicken decision making during warm up sketches. Finally, we contemplated and assessed a drawing by Matisse.

Next class we will begin drawing apples with a focus on tonal range. We will also practice intuitive gestures as a means of arranging compositions. Remember to answer the question on the back of the Cezanne drawing and be ready to discuss the PDF text on intuitive gesture, which can be found in an earlier announcement.

“Painting from nature is not copying the object; it is realizing one's sensations.” - Paul Cezanne

DAY 3: Intuitive Gesture with Apple and Leaf

During our third class we explored the technique of “intuitive gesture” in which lightly applied lines create a quick, all-encompassing overview of forms and their relationship in space. This technique is a fluid process and should not be viewed as right or wrong, but as progressive stages of perceptual sensitivity to help us sight measure. An apple was used as a model to study the effects of light on volume. Leaves were added to the apple, to demonstrate how a drawing can develop in stages. Incandescent lights were added to intensify the effects of shadows.

We also analyzed the Paul Cezanne still life drawing, describing the nervous quality of the contour lines, the thematic use of the oval in the composition, and the effect of his use of an ellipsis, a device where a portion of the drawing is omitted, allowing the audience to fill in the gaps. Please answer the questions for the Georges Seurat drawing for next class.

DAY 4: Intuitive Gesture w/ Fabric and Apples

We began the class with a demonstration of how to approach fabric drawing using intuitive gesture, followed by transforming these lines into tonal shapes. We folded the fabric searching for a dominate fold as an "anchor point," then we added three apples thinking of the "rule of three." Incandescent lights were added as the daylight changed, and we practiced using the shammy to apply a tonal background. I diagramed the anatomy of the human eye and described how it focuses and adjusts to light, all in contrast photography. We then did an experiment that revealed the “blind spot” in our vision, allowing you to sense how the mind sews together our perception. We analyzed the drawing by George Seurat, first describing its form, analyzing the effects of these forms, and then putting it all together into an evaluation. Please read the vocabulary and sublime / uncanny handouts and be ready to discuss for the next class.

“The object of art is not to reproduce reality, but to create a reality of the same intensity.” -Albert Giacometti

DAY 5: Fabric Apple Leaf Still Life / Sublime & Uncanny Lecture

In this class we continued to practice rendering the tonal folds of fabric. We included an apple and leaf in the drawing, as well as incandescent lights. We also practiced drawing atmospheric perspective, which refers to the effect the atmosphere has on the appearance of objects when seen from a distance. You see objects further back in the distance less clearly and their values lightens. As an artist you can increase the illusion of depth and feeling in your drawing by exaggerating this effect.

We also reviewed the "Sublime and Uncanny" handout. The sublime is an aesthetic experience of a quality that inspires an overwhelming emotion, a mixture of terror and pleasure, by confronting a viewer with something vast and beyond human control. The uncanny is an aesthetic experience that describes an unsettling feeling of strangeness in the familiar, where it represents the return of repressed childhood fears and beliefs. Both are examples of complex psychical experiences that art can activate. Please complete the analysis of the Giacometti drawing for next class.

DAY 6: Books & Ceramics / Linear Perspective / Gallery Trip

At the start of class we walked over to visit the faculty art show at the Art Gallery in Woodland Hall. We talked about the importance of seeing an artwork “in person” and how art interacts with our physical being. Each student was asked to pick an artwork and draw a quick sketch. Then we answered the list of questions we us to interpret an artwork. We describe, analyze, interpret, and evaluate the work. Following this I gave a presentation about my abstract painting and answered questions. I emphasized that my work states the "fact of fragmentation", but that it does not go the path of cynicism or relativism, but rather shows that the fragmentation can create an uplift, or a human value.

In this class, I demonstrated how to approach drawing books and ceramics. With these two new objects, we practiced linear perspective and drawing ellipses and employing plumb lines. A

Morandi handout was given at the end of class. Please be ready to discuss the Morandi and Giacometti handouts next class. Midterm reviews will begin next class. We will individually go through your portfolio and practice talking about your work. While it's not necessary, it's a great time to have "make up" work ready for review. We will pick one work to hang up for display.

DAY 7: Complex Still Life / Midterm reviews

Last class we set up a still life using all the objects in our repertoire. We approached drawing this as we have so far in class, by employing charcoal and working towards a degree of realism. Midterm portfolio reviews were completed, during which we practiced talking about the drawings and thinking about what makes them more or less successful. One drawing was chosen to hang on the classroom wall. Please review your midterm grades and complete any make up work. Also, be prepared to analyze the two hand out drawings by Morandi and Giacometti, which we will discuss during the next class.

DAY 8: Complex still life w/ Matte / Slide Show

We began class with a quick review of a new archival drawing paper and how it relates to a precut matte-board, which will frame the drawing for exhibition. We reviewed the idea of a trompe l'oeil drawing, which translate to "trick the eye"" and added a platform for the objects to sit upon in each still life. After the break, I presented a slide show tracing the idea of the still life

throughout history. We started with frescoes of food in ancient Pompeii, through to the German Renaissance with works by artist Albrecht Dürer, and into the modern era with Vincent van Gogh's Sunflowers and the Neoplasticism of Piet Mondrian. This lecture provides context for what we are practicing in class, and shows the variety of purposes and intentions the still life has embodied through history.

DAY 9: COMPLEX STILL LIFE w Matte

Today we continued to make trompe l'oeil drawings of our three objects, using all the skills we have practiced thus far in the class. This can be viewed as the culmination of our intention to create a representation that resembles what the eye can observe and to capture a certain degree of naturalistic authenticity. Moving forward in the class we will explore the expressive possibilities of charcoal, shifting into a more experimental intention toward our drawings. These drawings with be installed on the classroom wall framed with a matte. Next class we will have the artist Joe Noderer present his artwork and demonstrate the technique of reductive drawing.

DAY 10: VISITING ARTIST JOSEPH NODERER

Today we had Pittsburgh artist Joseph Noderer present his artwork to the class. He also brought a suite of drawings in graphite that he described as a ”fever dream” and one small painting of a forest bathed in orange light. Mr. Noderer showed early work from his undergraduate education at Tyler University to current paintings made recently here in Pittsburgh. He gave a personal narrative of how an interest in 1970’s horror films influenced the early paintings of figures in a forest, and how this evolved into an atmosphere which could evoked the same uncanny feeling without a figure. He talked about the influences of folk art and romantic landscape paintings of Albert Pinkham Ryder, and followed his lecture with examples. He talked about how his composition process uses contrast to “anchor the image” and create "scenes within scenes". He identified man-made structures, such as a shed, as a returning theme of the work, and how nature is depicted as both lush and menacing. He spoke about how as an artist you have to "make excuses" to allow yourself to make what you want. After answering questions from students, he demonstrated how to make a reduction drawing, using a charcoal field as the background into which you erasure.

DAY 11: Expressive Art Explorations

We began with a return to contour drawing. We studied a new set of leaves and practiced preliminary sketches to get to know the object. Next we created a tonal scale and explored a variety of marks with vine charcoal. Then an idea was introduced to the class, “unraveling” with the instructions to “draw the idea.” This is an open ended prompt that can be interpret in many ways and begins the process of connecting emotions with mark making. We then analyzed the Morandi and Giacometti drawings as a group. We noted how the hatching marks and the organic lines in the Morandi created a contradictory effect of “ruggedness and smoothness” and found the image both confusing and sublime. Next, in the Giacometti drawing, we identified “manic” lines and a composition that is “jumbled” on both sides, with a set of lifeless figures in the center. Finally, we talked about how the observation of nature, as invented in the Renaissance, can be the foundation for expressive drawing. We talked about how when we see the natural world, we can also find the “intimate in the exterior” or to put in another way, we find a part of ourselves outside in world.

DAY 12: Reductive Drawing with Fixative / Slide show

I write a review of each class activity because intention is central to the study of the humanities. We started with a set of new leaves and pine cones as our subjects. The lighting produced strong cast shadows and eliminated ambient light. We started with an intuitive gesture sketch, then using a paint brush, created subtle tonal shapes. Next we place a "field" of mid-tone grey over the image, followed by erasing back into the drawing. We also applied a thin coat of fixative to seal the charcoal to the paper to allow for a deeper layering. Finally we finished the details of the drawing with compressed charcoal. The mid-tone background added a feeling of endless space and a reduction of detail. I then presented a slide show about Metaphysical painting, which are images that explore questions that have to do with perception and emotion. The slide show began with the mysterious spaces of Giorgio de Chirico and followed the evolution of the still life painter Giorgio Morandi.

Next class we will have Pittsburgh based artist Leah Patgorski present her work. Ms. Patgorski's work span's sculpture, drawing, painting and installation. Her education is in Fine Art and

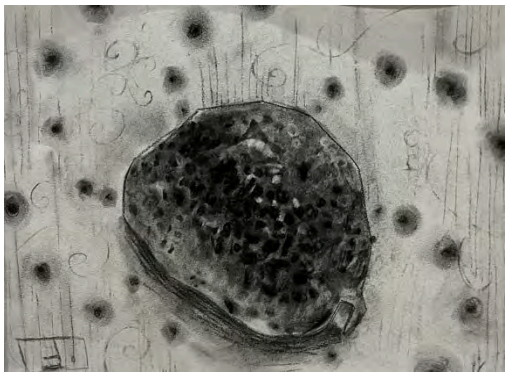
Architecture, and her works sits comfortably in both interior design and the museum. Please review her website before next class.

https://leahpatgorski.com/

DAY 13: VISITING ARTIST Leah Patgorski

For this class, we welcomed Pittsburgh based artist Leah Patgorski. Ms Patgorski creates large scale fabric installations, as well as three and two dimensional objects. Her unique education in both art and architecture provides her a perspective on current trends in the contemporary world. Ms Patgorski stated that architecture is designed around "premade products and components," both of which produce homogenization. Her proposed solution to this situation is to inject the hand-made and irregular color into these constructed spaces. Her projects utilies sketches to communicate ideas to clients and procure funding. She described about how she goes for a "floating" effect and that she strives to "hide the hardware." She discussed different natural dyes like indigo and madder root as ways to create color variations. When talking about her development as an artist she described how she was "inclined to make things" as a kid, and how when she finally started sewing fabric around age 21 she felt it really clicked. Her suggestion to the class is to "make your art for your friends," as a way to stay authentic. After our Q & A session, she demonstrated a model building project, where cut paper shapes are secured together using glue and strips of paper. These could create a flat or three dimensional object. The project had a relaxed approach, giving a wide range of options and results.

Having guest artists visit our class demonstrates how drawing is used today to develop ideas and expressive possibilities that engage our society. During the presentation we get a personal view of how an artistic practice develops over time, and we are exposed to new ways of approaching drawings. We get to "step into their shoes" of the artist and see the world through their subjective perspective.



DAY 14: REDUX Slide Show / BAUHAUS Project

Our second to last class started with a "Redux" slide show that reviewed all the ideas we discussed, techniques we practiced, and artist we studied this semester. I reviewed the pedagogical structure of the class, (Interpretation -Technical - Context) and how that aligned

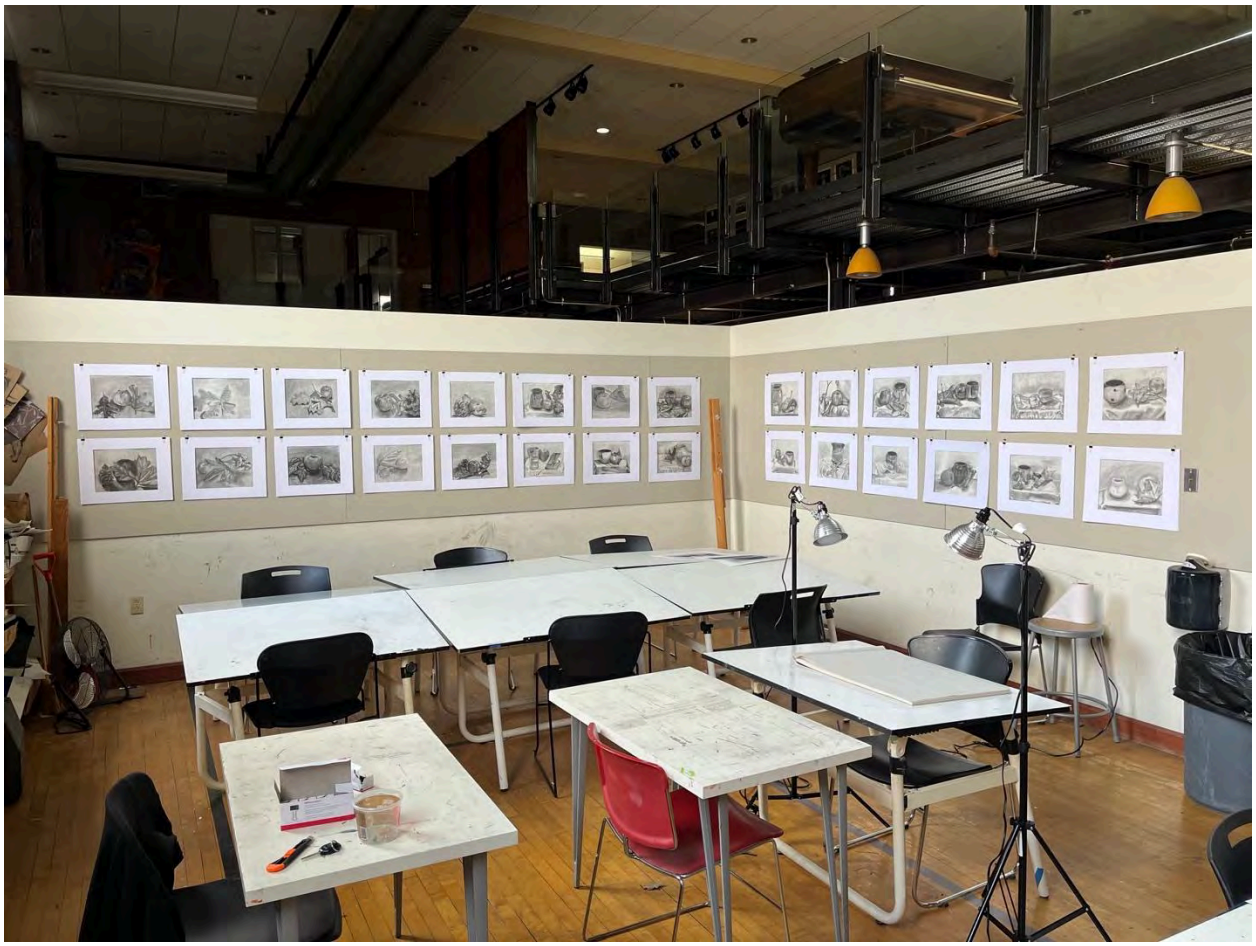
with our practice of analyzing drawings, observational drawing, and engaging with contemporary artists. Next we followed two assignments taken from the Bauhaus school in Germany. These assignments are prompted by opened questions that require you to “think fast” from your own subjectivity. The first one ask you to observe the “growth pattern” of an organic object (shells and milkweed pods) and extrapolate this form into a two dimensional design. Next second involved a set of instructions that force a constant readjustment of a previous formal decisions, highlighting an exploration of formal elements. Please bring any make up work that you would like reviewed to the next and final class. This class goes from 6-7:45, but you can stay till 9:00 to draw to finish make up work. Thursday will be the Survey event.

DAY 15: LIQUID CHARCOAL / MANDRADJIEFF SLIDE SHOW / WHY HUMANITIES?

For our final class, we rendered an apple and leaf with liquid charcoal and conte crayon stick on multi-media paper. After this I presented my artwork in a slide show, tracing my development as an artist as I moved between music, photography and painting. I answered the question "when is a work completed?" by stating that when something visual happens, that is unexpected to myself, then it is preserved. This event is left "as is", or compounded upon, creating layers that respond to each other in feeling, surface and touch. After this I presented a final slide show about why the humanities are important and the value that they manifest. Finally, everyone got to take an apple home.

Please remember to remove your drawings on the wall (leave the matte on my supply area) and take home your portfolio.

SURVEY SHOW INSTALLATION 2025



CLASS ROOM (PHOTO FROM ABOVE WALKWAY)